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SOUTH ASIAN POSTGRADUATE INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS' EMPLOYABILITY BARRIERS: A QUALITATIVE STUDY FROM AUSTRALIA AND THE UNITED KINGDOM

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ABSTRACT: *There is significant research on the motivations and migration experiences of South Asian international students in Australia and the United Kingdom (UK); however, the employability journeys of this group are not well understood. This article addresses this gap, illuminating the specific employability challenges experienced and perceived by South Asian postgraduate international students enrolled in Australia and the UK. Drawing on qualitative research comprising semi-structured interviews with 30 South Asian postgraduate international students studying at a university in Australia and in the UK, the findings highlight significant barriers to employability along four key axes: time pressures from study and adjustment issues (micro); lack of internship opportunities offered at the universities (meso); lack of culturally tailored university career services (meso) and perceptions of employers' as well as Government policy implications (macro). Acknowledging and understanding these findings are important for universities to support South Asian international student employability experiences and graduate outcomes to remain competitive in the global job market. The findings suggest recommendations to enhance the employability of South Asian students in the UK and Australia.*

Keywords: *South Asian, postgraduate international students, employability, Australia, the United Kingdom*

1. INTRODUCTION

Australia and the United Kingdom (UK) steadily attracted large numbers of international students, pre-COVID-19. In 2019, there were 952,271 international students studying in Australia (Department of Education, Skills and Employment, 2021). In the UK, there were 538,615 international students in 2019/2020 of which 142,985

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were from the European Union (EU) and 395,630 were non-EU (UUK, 2021). In Australia, international students come largely from Asian countries: 38.4% of the international students were of Chinese background followed by Indians (19%) and Nepalis (7.8%) (Department of Education, 2020; Department of Education, Skills and Employment, 2021). Similarly, in the UK, Chinese students accounted for the greatest number of international students, with 139,130 (25.8%) and followed by India with 52,454 (9.7%) students in 2019/2020 (UUK, 2021). International education, Australia's largest service export, was worth \$40.3 billion (approximately £22 billion) to the Australian economy (Department of Education, Skills and Employment, 2020). In the UK, in the 2018/19 academic year, the total net impact of international students on the UK economy was estimated to be £25.9 billion (approximately \$47.6 billion) (HEPI, 2021).

International students seek international education to experience international life and enhance their global employability and employment outcomes through gaining human and social capitals (Huang and Turner, 2018; Huang, 2013; Singh and Fan, 2021; Singh & Jack, 2018). As Chinese students have previously led the international student's population in Australia and the UK, numerous studies have explored Chinese students' and graduates' employability experiences (Huang and Turner, 2018; Singh and Fan, 2021). Whilst there is research on South Asian students in Australia and the UK, it is skewed towards understanding their motivations to study abroad (Cameron *et al.*, 2019; Johnson and Kumar, 2010; King and Sondhi, 2018) and their migration experiences (Hawthorne, 2014). There is a paucity of data on South Asian students' employability experiences, despite being a sizeable international student population with long-term intentions to stay in host countries for employment and settlement purposes (Cameron *et al.*, 2019; Crawford and Wang, 2016; Huang and Turner, 2018). The purpose of this study is to explore the perceived barriers to employability faced by international students from South Asia studying at a UK and Australian-based university.

2. UNDERSTANDING EMPLOYABILITY RELATING TO INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS

Employability refers to 'a set of skills and/or attributes that are necessary for any graduate to move into the [employment] market, to find and retain jobs and to develop [their] career' (Tran, 2016, p. 61). Recent research indicates that international students want to gain employment and career opportunities not only in the host countries but also in their home countries or even third countries, based on their accumulated international qualifications and skills (Campbell *et al.*, 2020; Singh and Fan, 2021; Singh, 2018). Therefore, it is vital to provide a meaningful, supportive and safe learning environment for international students to not only achieve their academic success but also strengthening their employability.

Tomlinson (2008) argued that providing and acquiring human capital alone will not suffice, as only possessing hard knowledge and limited skills of know-how

through a degree program will not position a graduate for employment in the current competitive labour market. For Tomlinson (2017), the Graduate Capital Model (GCM) provides a framework for students to enhance their employability through building their social, cultural, identity and psychological capitals. In terms of social capital, international students can build social relationships and networks while studying through placements or internship opportunities or even building connections with their lecturers who are valuable in sourcing employment information. Building connections is vital to obtaining subsequent employment either in the host or home countries. However, Singh and Fan (2021) found that international students are weak in forming networks with future employers. This is because they do not take initiatives and spend insufficient time building social networks that could be valuable for their future job searches.

Nevertheless, international students can accumulate culturally valued knowledge, dispositions and behaviours that are aligned to the workplaces they have aspirations for through work integrated learning (WIL) programs supported by the universities. These programs include 'practicum, professional practice, internship, workplace learning, industry-based learning, project-based learning, cooperative education, fieldwork education, service learning, real-world learning, university engaged learning, experiential learning, clinical placements, work experience, clinical practice, doctoral supervision with industry partners, and work-based learning' (Oliver, 2015, p. 60). Australian and UK-based research studies have discovered that international students had better employment outcomes, exposure to local work culture and enhanced their employability skills, such as communication and teamwork as they undertook WIL placements (Crawford and Wang, 2016; Gribble and McRae, 2017; Jackson, 2017).

In addition to WIL, participating in extra and/or co-curricular activities (Tran, 2017) such as student clubs or societies, student exchange, overseas study programs, students' participation in staff research publications, and sporting groups (Bartkus *et al.*, 2012; Nghia, 2019; Tran, 2017), assists international students in developing cultural capital. Specifically, Buckley and Lee (2018) suggest that participation in these activities is perceived as a positive sign in enhancing students' workplace culture as well as acquiring skills such as communication, self-management and confidence, teamwork and problem solving, which are highly demanded by employers (Khoo *et al.*, 2018). Most importantly, Tomlinson (2017) argued that participation in extra-curricular activities can be recorded in a student's career portfolio and be shown at job interviews to demonstrate that they have engaged in workplace culture, acquired employability skills as well as built their identity psychosocial components.

Pham (2021) advocated that for international students to achieve positive employment outcomes, they have to exercise agentic capital. According to Pham (2021) agentic capital is the capacity to develop effective and strategic approaches in combining and using various forms of capital as proposed by Tomlinson (2017) to achieve optimal and successful employability outcomes. Tomlinson's GCM

framework and Pham's (2021) agentic capital underpin this study's theoretical framework to further unpack South Asian postgraduate international students' employability barriers and strategies to develop employability. However, this framework was tested mainly with domestic graduates (Pham *et al.*, 2019) as well as with Chinese and Vietnamese international graduates (Pham, 2021; Singh and Fan, 2021) but not with South Asian postgraduate students studying in Australia and the UK. It is important to acknowledge that employability development of international students and graduates is not homogenous due to the highly heterogeneous group of students; hence, this study fills in the gap of understanding the employability barriers endured by South Asian postgraduate students.

3. BARRIERS TO EMPLOYABILITY EXPERIENCED BY INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS

At the micro level, international students face challenges due to the unfamiliarity of academic and social environments in the host countries and institutions. For instance, academic adjustment main challenges include English language proficiency as well as engagement with lecturers/supervisors and other students (Singh and Jack, 2022). Social adjustment issues include friendship with students (Singh and Jack, 2022), financial, and accommodation (Calder *et al.*, 2016). Psychological/emotional barriers include loneliness, isolation and homesickness (Li *et al.*, 2014). Studies have suggested that adjustment to the new environment is a significant contributor to international students' academic success and employability (Singh, 2018).

At meso level, universities offer career services to students connected to developing students' employability skills. This may include resume writing, interview skills, and career counselling. (Yang *et al.*, 2002). However, recent research by Fakunle and Pirrie (2020) as well as Singh (2020a, 2023), argued that career services provided for international students are not tailored to address specific career challenges faced by international students, such as goals setting, career development and management, specific advice on writing industry-related resumes, network with industry professionals, locating jobs or planning for a career either in the home, host or third countries.

Career fairs are another type of initiative offered for students to converse with prospective employers to gain information about their roles or positions and acquire an understanding of what it is like to work within a specific organisation (Nicholas and Handley, 2019). The fairs also promote industry networking events and industry mentoring schemes (Bridgstock and Jackson, 2019) and are mainly to build 'students' social capital and professional networks' (Bridgstock and Jackson, 2019, p. 470) with the prospective employers. However, research suggests that employers at these fairs are mainly focused on domestic students as opposed to international students due to their perceived work-related visa restrictions (Arkoudis *et al.*, 2019).

Further, universities provide internship opportunities to increase students' employability. Chan (2011) and Nghia (2019) argued that either paid or unpaid internships are useful for students to gain relevant work experience, technical skills, and soft skills to increase their employability (Cheong *et al.*, 2014). However, international students' participation in the WIL-related internship activities have been found to be low, as they are largely focused on acquiring human capital – qualifications rather than participating in WIL programs as indicated in previously (Gribble and McRae, 2017). Internship opportunities are also not easily accessible to international students in the United Kingdom as there are 'inadequate signposting of work placement information across the institution' (Goodwin and Mbah, 2019, p. 524) in contrast to domestic students who are well informed of the opportunities. Similar challenge is also faced in Australia in terms of limited distribution of internship-related information to international students (Gribble, 2014). Jackson (2018, p. 24) further encapsulated that universities lack 'coordination role [and] these extra-curricular internships may also not be governed by the good practice principles critical to a quality work-based learning experience' for international students.

At macro level, employers in the host country have different perspectives in providing job opportunities to international students. International students do perceive that they are discriminated against by employers due to their visa status, low English proficiency and unsupportive behaviour to recruit international students (Singh, 2020b). Although employers acknowledge advantages in employing international students in host countries, these advantages are not always positively received by the employers where the visa status of international students becomes an issue. International students perceived that Australian and the UK employers often reluctant to employ international students primarily because they are neither citizens nor permanent residents of the host country (Fakunle and Pirrie, 2020; Singh, 2020b).

Despite significant barriers experienced by international students relating to employability, these studies have captured the experiences of international students as a homogenous group. They provide a one-size-fits-all approach to assist international students in developing their employability in the host country. Specifically, the current literature on employability of international students have typically focused on the experiences of either Chinese or Vietnamese international students and graduates (Author, 2020b). These cohorts of students and graduates are likely to return to their home countries or third countries for employment purposes (Singh, 2020b; Tharenou and Seet, 2014). However, South Asian students and graduates, are more likely to stay back in the host countries to seek employment due to a two-step migration phenomenon (Hawthorne, 2014). Cameron *et al.* (2019), King and Sondhi (2018) as well as Hawthorne (2014) argued that South Asian students, especially students from India, are referred to as two-step migration intenders as their main intention is to

gain employment, permanent residency or citizenship upon graduation in the host country. Hawthorne (2014) established that there is a 'complex interplay of migration and education policies' (p. 3) which led to high enrolments of South Asian students in Australia and the UK.

Given the two-step migration complexity as proposed by Cameron *et al.* (2019), the research explored in this paper makes a significant contribution to the body of research in relation to the employability challenges faced by South Asian international students in Australia and the UK.

4. RESEARCH DESIGN AND METHODOLOGY

A qualitative approach was employed to elicit and examine the experiences, perceptions, beliefs and understandings of employability held by postgraduate international students of South Asian background in Australia and the UK. The aim of the study was to explore the barriers in enhancing employability of South Asian postgraduate international students in Australia and in the UK. A symbolic interactionist approach underpinned this study (Plummer, 1996). A key aspect of this approach considers people's actions and behaviours, which are based on the subjective meanings attributed in turn affecting choices and behaviours. This framing allowed for an exploration and garnering an understanding of the South Asian students' employability experiences and the meaning or interpretation they assigned to their experiences.

Interview was the main method of data collection. Semi-structured interviews were used to obtain, understand, unfold and explore in depth the experiential views of participants (Kvale, 2007). Thirty interviews were conducted with 15 postgraduate students from South Asia enrolled at La Trobe University (LTU), Australia and 15 enrolled at Manchester Metropolitan University (MMU), the UK between 2019 and 2020. In Melbourne, the interviews were conducted via zoom as this coincided with the COVID-19 pandemic restrictions, which were in place from March 2020; however, all UK interviews had been concluded by the point restrictions came into place. All interviews were carried out in English at a mutually convenient time/location (either via Zoom or face-to-face) by authors in Australia and in the UK. The duration of the interviews ranged from 20 to 60 min. Participants were recruited through social media and a snowball sampling technique was also adopted, where participants who had consented to an interview were invited to suggest other students who met the criteria to participate (Minichiello *et al.*, 2008). The criteria included: 1) postgraduate international students from various disciplines 2) enrolled full time in the respective universities and 3) willing to share and articulate their employability perceptions. This study received ethical clearance from the LTU Human Research Ethics Committee (HEC19345) and the MMU Business and Law Research Ethics and Governance Committee (EthOS Reference Number: 11870).

In this study, there were a greater number of female participants from both settings (Australia = 73%, $n = 11$ and UK = 60%, $n = 9$). The marital status of majority of the participants was single (Australia = 53%, $n = 8$ and UK = 93%, $n = 14$). Most students in Australia were supported financially through scholarships (47%) or family support (33%) in comparison to students in the UK who were largely supported by family support (73%). The average time spent studying at the institutions varied (Australia 16.4 months vs. UK 6.4 months). Table 1 shows demographic details of participants studied at MMU and Table 2 shows demographic details of participants studied at LTU. The following convention have been used for the tables and in reporting the qualitative comments:

P stands for participant, followed by an interview number as well as a location identifier for both the UK and Australia (i.e., P 1 UK, P 2 Aus).

An interview topic guide was used including topics related to employability experiences and expectations. This was used flexibly using an iterative approach enabling probing of issues deemed important by both participant and interviewer. This iterative approach was used in the data collection and analysis to enhance and refine the data (Minichiello *et al.*, 2008). Data analysis was conducted concurrently to recruitment to ascertain when theoretical saturation was reached (Minichiello *et al.*, 2008). The interviews were transcribed verbatim by professional transcription services. Respondent validation was carried out by sending participants their interview transcripts for review (Birt *et al.*, 2016).

Using the principles of inductive thematic analysis, codes and themes were generated from the data (Braun and Clarke, 2006). In addition to this, content analysis was performed by ascertaining the number of different participants who articulated

TABLE 1. Postgraduate international students' demographics at MMU

Participant ID	Gender	Nationality	Faculty or School	Length of time at Institution
P1 UK	Female	Indian	Arts and Humanities	6 months
P2 UK	Female	Indian	Arts and Humanities	6 months
P3 UK	Female	Indian	Health and Education	4 months
P4 UK	Male	Indian	Business and Law	5 months
P5 UK	Female	Indian	Business and Law	6 months
P6 UK	Male	Indian	Business and Law	12 months
P7 UK	Male	Indian	Architecture	12 months
P8 UK	Female	Indian	Health and Education	2 months
P9 UK	Female	Indian	Architecture	12 months
P10 UK	Male	Indian	Business and Law	6 months
P11 UK	Female	Indian	Health and Education	4 months
P12 UK	Male	Indian	Business and Law	6 months
P13 UK	Male	Indian	Business and Law	5 months
P14 UK	Female	Indian	Architecture	5 months
P15 UK	Female	Indian	Health and Education	5 months

TABLE 2. Postgraduate international students' demographics at LTU

Participant ID	Gender	Nationality	Faculty or School	Length of time at Institution
P1 Aus	Male	Indian	Business	24 months
P2 Aus	Female	Indian	Public Health	6 months
P3 Aus	Female	Indian	Public Health	6 months
P4 Aus	Female	Indian	Public Health	6 months
P5 Aus	Male	Indian	Physiology, Anatomy and Microbiology	12 months
P6 Aus	Female	Sri Lankan	Physiology, Anatomy and Microbiology	36 months
P7 Aus	Female	Indian	Physiology, Anatomy and Microbiology	28 months
P8 Aus	Female	Indian	Physiology, Anatomy and Microbiology	12 months
P9 Aus	Female	Indian	Business	18 months
P10 Aus	Male	Indian	Computer Science	2 months
P11 Aus	Female	Sri Lankan	Business	24 months
P12 Aus	Male	Indian	Computer Science	18 months
P13 Aus	Female	Nepali	Nursing and Midwifery	24 months
P14 Aus	Female	Indian	Computer Science	12 months
P15 Aus	Female	Indian	Computer Science	18 months

a specific theme. All authors independently coded and compared 10 transcripts. Following this, the researchers discussed the codes and possible themes, which were reviewed and refined at the broader level of themes as suggested by Braun and Clarke (2006). Themes relating to barriers of employability perceived by postgraduate international students from South Asian backgrounds were confirmed by the research team before further analysis was performed. This process enhanced trustworthiness of interpretations whilst ensuring inter-rater reliability (Minichiello *et al.*, 2008).

5. RESULTS

There were four key barriers induced from the data analysis. These are underpinned by micro, meso and macro levels: time pressures from academic adjustment issues (micro); lack of internship opportunities offered (meso); unsuitability of the university careers services (meso) and perceptions of employers' as well as government policy requirements (macro).

Academic Adjustment Issues (Micro Level)

An emerging theme related to the difficulties of finding time to pursue meaningful employability opportunities. In particular, students reported demands of the course and managing the academic transition at the host institution, limit their time available to gain related employability skills. Gaining academic success in terms of course completion was an important factor for them as opposed to enhancing their employability while studying which is also reflected in cultural differences of the host and home countries:

I just do not want to mix up everything. I want to complete my PhD on time. If I am going to be working outside, I know that, I would not be able to concentrate on my studies properly. I think for now I have got already too much on my plate. [P7, Aus]

We are not from that kind of [culture]. We didn't work in India. We don't work, not at all work in India but after coming here, we have to work. All sorts of job. That's okay we don't that like we don't feel inferior to do something or nothing but even after doing something. [P4, Aus]

In the UK, this theme was reflected in students identifying the differences between their home country learning experiences and those in the UK resulting in little free time for other experiences, such as developing their employability:

Difficulty of adjusting to the UK approach to study and the transition to that made it more difficult to engage in work opportunities. [P2, UK]

I am still kind of trying to finish the semester and right now it's like I am focused on like finishing [the studies]. I will think about it [employability] probably later, when I am done with the semester work. [P14, UK]

Since I have put a lot of effort in developing my academics skills after coming here because they are very different than what we are used to in India. So, I thought giving that 48 hours of the week to enhance my employability will not be possible for me. [P9, UK]

The participants in this study reflected the barriers arising from the pressures of transition and prioritisation of academic success in terms of completing the degree rather than gaining employability skills.

Lack of Internship Opportunities (Meso Level)

The students mirrored each other in both national contexts by reporting the importance of work experience, placements, and internships. However, the majority of students from both institutions reported a key barrier to achieving this as a result of internship availability within programmes.

In the UK, the barriers were reported as being about the quality of internship offering and the availability of internship experiences, with a common theme being that there are '*no opportunities for internship, placement, or other employability-related activities. Nothing related to careers and employability*' [P11, UK]. In addition, several students explicitly mentioned their disappointment relating to internships or placements offering:

I have not been offered any internship at the university. Apparently, there are many universities which offer one year of studies and one year of industrial placements. But unfortunately, I did not get that at this university. [P4, UK]

Nothing related to careers and employability. This includes no opportunities for internship, placement, and other activities related to employability within the course. [P11, UK]

We don't get any particular experience right now it is just theory that we learn. So, we are not shadowing anyone or we do not have any kind of practical experience. [P8, UK]

However, in Australia, the students often identified opportunities as being available within their programmes of study. The quotations below give a flavour of the general feeling students presented about being an international citizen:

We are supposed to receive some industrial experience next semester. But I think, throughout the semester, it is very hard for international students to get any specific role in cybersecurity. This is because it deals with security. A lot of organisations do not want to take you as you an international student. I think they prefer an Australian citizen opposed to international. [P12, Aus]

I have not searched yet [for internships in Australia]. In India it is pretty easy from internshala. Internshala is a good website. I have got an internship from there only ... in institutes mainly Bangalore, Kerala in Cochin, it is there, in Bangalore, Pune, Chennai. There itself you will get internship automatically. I do not know the system in Australia. [P10, Aus]

Although international students in Australia value internship opportunities, however, participants reported anxieties related to their international status disadvantaging them in gaining internship opportunities in Australia as well as limited knowledge on navigating the systems to gain internships.

Issues with University Career Services (Meso Level)

Based on the interviews, one of the barriers relating to employability is that students faced issues with their institutional careers' services. The services offered by career offices are not being tailored to international students' needs. For example, students have mentioned that:

A lot of the career shows, that they do at university is probably geared towards domestic students than international. [P12, Aus]

I did use the career hub and everything but then I guess something did not go right. Like, I was unable to get that particular help from the university regarding my internships. Even though they would provide us with the newsletter that we received every fortnight or every week. And I would go through the requirements and it did say that I am eligible but at the end, that is only for PR and citizens. [P9, Aus]

I decide like whenever there is an employability events such as careers fair, I go and talk to the firms like what are your expectations for international students to come and work. Most of the answer is like literally less employers are interested in sponsoring international students. [P7, UK]

In both institutions, students do report a range of employability support being available from the institutions' career services but felt that most events were

geared towards assisting domestic students gaining employment. Further, where students have approached careers services for support, the knowledge has not been reflective of the needs of international students and their specific circumstances. This leaves students with little tailored guidance to build confidence in applying for positions and believing in their own employment success.

I mean I did go to the career office and asked them if they have umm . . . a list of employers who might take some interview after we graduate but they didn't have anything like that. That was disappointing. [P8, UK]

I was trying to see if I can get my CV improved. And he sent me some templates back, and I'm going, that's not what I wanted. I was hoping to get some more personal help. I just didn't feel like university is genuinely there to support international students. [P12, Aus]

The findings show that students experience challenges in obtaining the full value of careers support within their universities. Tailoring the service to provide specialist advice, guidance, and support for students would help overcome their employability barriers.

Students' Experience and Their Perceptions of Employers and Government Policies (Macro Level)

Concerns around the environment for international students within workplaces included cultural issues, employer's perceptions of international students, and the impact of government policy on employer hiring decisions emerged from the data. Students shared concerns about their status and felt that this impacted employer perceptions towards them in providing related employment opportunities. There were notable differences in how students reported the perceived root cause of concerns. In Australia, respondents openly cited racism within the recruitment process as a causal factor but this was not mentioned in the UK.

Actually, I am looking for a job. I already attended a lot of interviews but I think due to racism, I did not get any job. [P3, Aus]

I am not from an Australian background so that is one of the major issues. I will get much more benefits and opportunities if I was an Aussie. I think this is a major reason. They [Australian domestic students] belong to Australia. They understand the regions and the conditions. Like back in India, we can understand like every state have a different mindset and mentality. [P1, Aus]

I used to apply but most of the jobs asked that at least you should have like temporary residence or permanent residence. I just go and ask about graduate programs and internship and they said that for me it is no point of applying for graduate role or internship programs. They said why do not you try for like some consultancy or something but for that you have to have like Permanent Resident or Temporary Resident because they don't take them on contract basis. International students have a problem as they have work restrictions and employers are not sure

whether you are going to stay here or not and there is a big cost to the company. And I think they prefer Australian citizen. [P11, Aus]

Whilst UK participants did not explicitly mention racism as a factor, they did identify associated barriers around cultural issues in the workplace. This demonstrated a lack of confidence in their ability to thrive in a UK workplace due to their language proficiency:

I don't know how office in the UK runs but I have an idea how offices in India runs. I don't know how office culture is in the UK. When it comes to language, I was really bad at picking up accents. I am building on my communication skills. I hope that will help me in getting a job. [P7, UK]

As an international student I would say the cultural approaches would be a problem because people behave differently here as people behave differently in India. So, in handling patients directly: What you are allowed to say and how much you are allowed to do? So that will be kind of something you need to figure your way out. [P11, UK]

The UK participants were more likely than Australian participants to cite the UK Government Visa policy as a barrier:

Well over here, the fact I am an international student makes it very hard for me to secure a job because they (employers) prefer graduates who already have a visa to stay here but since I do not have that, it just makes it 10 times harder for me. [P8, UK]

For domestic students they can work full time while they are studying. But for me since I am on student visa, I can only search for a part-time role, meaning that I can only work for a maximum of 20 hour weeks or so and there are not many opportunities available for part-time job. I believe students for who are enrolling in UK universities from the year 2020 to 2021, they have an extra two years after their graduation to stay in the UK and look for a job. Since I am enrolled in the previous year, 2019, I don't have that option. So, I have considerably less time period to stay back and search for a job here. So that brings me as a small amount of disadvantage compared to students, which joining from this year onwards. [P6, UK]

During the period of study, the UK was operating under a restrictive visa regime for students from India. Subsequently, the visa rules were relaxed to allow students the right to remain for two years post study. However, the visa barriers identified by students in both countries also related to the number of hours they were allowed to work as an international student versus domestic students.

6. DISCUSSION

The study explored employability barriers of South Asian postgraduate international students at universities in Australia and the UK. There were four key employability-related barriers underpinned by: time pressures from study and

adjustment issues (micro); lack of internship opportunities offered at the universities (meso); unsuitability of the university careers services (meso) and employers' perceptions as well as government policy requirements (macro).

At micro level, South Asian postgraduate international students from Australia and the UK argued that academic achievement in terms of focusing on their studies and course completion are more important as compared to developing their employability in the host countries. This is because South Asian higher education systems place more value towards academic skills with little emphasis on extracurricular and employability-related skills (Vyas and Chauhan, 2013). Although, Tomlinson (2008) strongly suggests that possessing qualifications (human capital) alone will not suffice for international students and graduates to compete in the labour market, international students in this study have limited time to develop their employability because they are focusing their energy on coping with academic and social stresses from being in a new learning environment. Postgraduate students in this study repeatedly identified being unable to engage in employability-related activities outside of their programme of study as the adjustment process meant their full focus was required to succeed in their studies. South Asian students have a very high commitment towards their studies due to parental and cultural expectations to succeed whilst gaining overseas qualifications as argued by Johnson and Kumar (2010) and King and Sondhi (2018). However, if international students do not balance their academic and social challenges with employability challenges, they will be disadvantaged in their career development journey.

At the meso level, South Asian postgraduate students face a lack of internship opportunities provided by host universities to enhance their work experience, develop workplace culture understanding and international identity as proposed by Tomlinson (2017). Postgraduate international students in Australia argued that opportunities were provided mainly to domestic students due to their residency status. Cheong *et al.* (2014) and Huang (2013) further found that students with internship experience were more likely to be hired by employers as perceptions were that they could quickly adapt to the work culture, apply in practice what they had learned in theory and be skilled in their job in a shorter timeframe. International students do acknowledge, and are aware of, these benefits of engaging in internship or placement opportunities (Huang *et al.*, 2014) but they face barriers in obtaining internship due to lack of support from universities and/or employers in addition to the difficulties faced during the COVID-19 pandemic restrictions. However, Jackson (2018) suggests that 'students must understand [that] they share responsibility for their own career-readiness' (p. 30) and they need to think out of the box in sourcing and engaging with activities such as internship for their personal and professional career development.

Universities in the UK and Australia provide employability-related assistance to students via their career service activities that cater to the 'one-size fits all' notion. For example, limited personalised advice was provided in developing resumes and career

fairs or shows mainly targeted at domestic students as employers were not keen to sponsor international students upon graduation (Singh, 2023). Similar recent findings were found by the Higher Education Policy Institute and Kaplan report (Hillman, 2021). In this report, international students mentioned career support (82%) and enhancing employability skills (92%) were the most important indicators for them to choose UK universities to study (Hillman, 2021). However, only 52% were satisfied with the career support provided by their universities (Hillman, 2021). The standardised career services offered to students in Australia and the UK (Atlay and Harris, 2000; Singh, 2020a) have failed to provide international students support in gaining employment, let alone building their graduate capitals, such as identity, cultural, psychological, agentic and social as proposed by Tomlinson (2017) and Pham's (2021). As South Asian postgraduate students are keen to stay on and develop their careers in the UK and Australia, higher education institutions have a responsibility and should provide culturally relevant careers services tailoring to international students' differing needs. This includes educating employers on policy and rights to work for international students; targeted career counselling support for international students that addresses cultural differences particularly related to the workplace environments which should include tailored support with transition to host countries for employment purposes.

The macro-level barrier experienced by South Asian postgraduate international students in this study relates to perceptions of employers' and government policies surrounding visa restrictions. Findings from this study suggest that international students felt that their visa status and ethnic background affected employers hiring decisions. Concerningly, some postgraduate international students in Australia reported perceived racism of not being given employment opportunities based on their ethnicity. Similar findings have been noted by Hebbani and Colic-Peisker (2012) who found racism and discrimination are key issues faced by migrant communities in Australia in securing employment. Nevertheless, both the Australian and UK students felt they had limited understanding of the workplace and broader cultural and linguistic aspects of the host country, which disadvantaged them in comparison to the domestic students (Tomlinson, 2017). Australia and the UK have been seen as countries where one can settle and have a decent quality of life with pathways that allowed for this education-migration nexus (Hawthorne and To, 2014; Hawthorne, 2014; King and Sondhi, 2018). This barrier has significantly impacted South Asian students' intentions to stay in Australia and the UK mainly for employment and career development purposes.

7. CONCLUSION

The findings on barriers to employability of postgraduate international students from South Asian backgrounds in Australia and the UK address a gap in the literature (Cameron *et al.*, 2019; Huang and Turner, 2018; Singh and Fan, 2021) by providing a more nuanced understanding at micro, meso, and macro levels. At the micro level,

South Asian postgraduate international students faced academic and social adjustment issues that hindered them in developing their employability while studying. At the meso level, there was a lack of institutional assistance in providing internship opportunities and culturally related career services for South Asian postgraduate international students to enhance their employability. At the macro level, the students faced biased employers and government visa issues surrounding their work rights. These research findings have made an empirical contribution through exploring the experiences of postgraduate international students from South Asian backgrounds in the UK and Australia, uncovering, at a deeper level, the challenges to employability, underpinned by the GFC framework proposed by Tomlinson (2017) and agentic capital by Pham's (2021).

There are significant implications at all levels. At the micro level, South Asian postgraduate international students are aware that to gain successful employment upon graduation, they need to obtain related work experiences via internship opportunities and to engage with the institutional career services. However, they faced barriers in doing this, coupled with negative perceptions from employers on their visa status, language proficiency, and lack of workplace culture. More so, they have academic adjustment issues that adds additional stress in managing their time to enhance their employability. At the meso level, higher education institutions need to pay closer attention to the needs of international students by providing specific career-related services and driving internship opportunities and industry linkages. At macro level, policymakers can clearly devise the visa conditions of international students and graduates in terms of their work rights and inform employers of these changes.

Several limitations were observed: firstly, the findings cannot be representative of all postgraduate international students as they only reflected responses from postgraduate South Asian students studying at two universities in Australia and the UK. Future research may include more postgraduate international students from wider South Asian countries as well as from universities within the US, Canada, other European countries, China, and Malaysia; secondly, future research could be conducted with South Asian graduates to investigate factors that facilitate their employability, employment and career experiences in the UK and Australia, specifically focusing on the diaspora social/cultural networks. Notwithstanding, this study adds to the knowledge of employability challenges experienced by South Asian postgraduate international students in the UK and Australia and offers a much-needed international perspective to ongoing research.

8. DISCLOSURE STATEMENT

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